

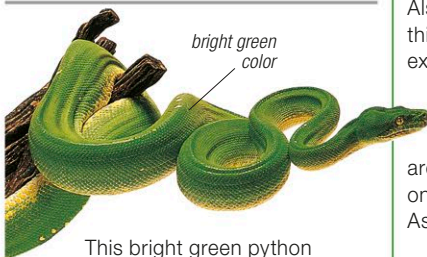
Morelia viridis

Green tree python



Length 6–7¼ ft (1.8–2.4 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Arboreal
Status Least concern

Location New Guinea and surrounding islands, extreme N. Australia



bright green color

This bright green python has the same adaptations for an arboreal lifestyle—slender shape, prehensile tail, and green coloration—as the emerald tree boa (see p.390). It also rests and hunts in the same way, coiled around a branch with its head hanging down ready to strike at prey. All the scales around the mouth have prominent heat pits. Females lay 6–30 eggs in a tree hole or among epiphytic plants. The young—which are bright yellow or occasionally red—are hunted by birds of prey.

Python molurus

Burmese python



Length 16–23 ft (5–7 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Vulnerable

Location S. and S.E. Asia



Also known as the Indian python, this very large snake is afforded excellent camouflage by the pattern of interlocking, dark brown blotches on its buff or gray skin. The coloration varies from area to area, but the “arrowhead” marking on the top of the head is constant. As with all pythons, there are heat

pits along the jaws. Once adult, this snake has no predators, but it will hiss, strike, or bite if threatened; its bite, however, is neither venomous nor dangerous to humans. A powerful constrictor, the Burmese python feeds on mammals and birds, ambushing and constricting prey as large as a deer. It may estivate in the drier parts of its range. Females, which are larger than males, usually lay 18–55 eggs at a time, in tree hollows or scrapes in the ground, and regulate their temperature until they hatch. By trembling its muscles, the Burmese python can generate enough heat to raise its own body temperature while it incubates its eggs. Population numbers have been seriously affected as a result of habitat destruction, and the Burmese python is now a legally protected species.



cryptic coloring

arrowhead mark

Python regius

Royal python



Length 2½–4 ft (0.8–1.2 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

Location W. to C. Africa



The royal python is short and stocky, with intricate, dark brown markings over a tan or yellowish background, and conspicuous heat pits around its mouth. It defends itself against predators such as mammals and birds by curling up into a ball and hiding its head in the center. In the dry season, this snake may estivate underground. Females lay and incubate a clutch of 3–8 eggs among rocks and in underground chambers.

Python reticulatus

Reticulated python



Length 20–33 ft (6–10 m)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location S.E. Asia



interlocking black marks



smooth scales

This python is the world’s longest snake and may weigh up to 440 lb (200 kg). It has a yellow or tan body with black markings, and prominent heat pits along the jaws. It can swim well but spends more time on

land than in water, seldom straying far from its den. The reticulated python eats birds, mammals and, very rarely, humans. The female lays and broods 30–50 eggs in hollow trees and underground chambers. This python may live up to 30 years. It is widely hunted for its skin and larger individuals are becoming increasingly rare.

Tropidophis melanurus

Cuban wood snake



Length 32–39 in (80–100 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

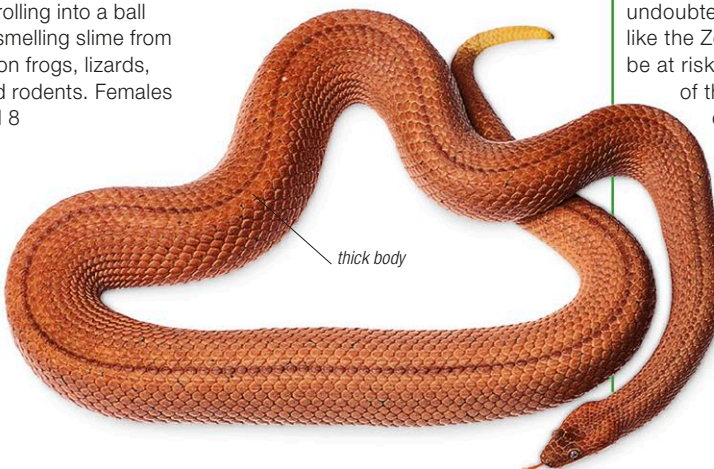
Location Caribbean



This stocky snake is commonly gray, brown, or buff, with darker markings and a black-tipped tail; it may also be orange, with a yellow-tipped tail. Living

mainly on the ground, occasionally climbing into bushes or onto rocks, it defends itself by rolling into a ball or releasing a foul-smelling slime from its cloaca. It feeds on frogs, lizards, smaller snakes, and rodents. Females give birth to around 8 young at a time.

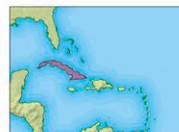
UNUSUAL COLORATION
The lighter orange coloration is much more rare than the darker morph. This snake is the largest in genus *Tropidophis*.



thick body

Tropidophis morenoi

Zebra dwarf boa



Length 12 in (30 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Not evaluated

Location Caribbean



So-called because of its banded pattern—formed by fused brown spots on a buff-colored background—this species belongs to a group of tropical American dwarf boas (also called wood snakes), most of which live on the ground. A large number of species have striking color patterns. They have evolved into a great many species within the Caribbean region and reach their highest diversity on the island of Cuba. Other species undoubtedly await discovery. Many—like the Zebra dwarf boa—may be at risk of extinction because of their very restricted island distributions. Dwarf boas stay hidden in low vegetation or even underground during the day and emerge under the cover of night to feed on small vertebrates—including other snakes. They give birth to live young in typical boa fashion.